

Unit Y301: The Early-Anglo Saxons c.400–800

This theme focuses on the arrival of the Anglo-Saxons in Britain and Ireland and the impact this had on politics, religion, the economy, society and culture. Learners should consider both the extent and reasons for political, religious economic, social and cultural change. Learners should consider how far, and for what reasons, this relationship changed. The strands

identified below are not to be studied in isolation to each other.

Learners are not expected to demonstrate a detailed understanding of the specification content, except for the named in-depth studies, but are expected to know the main developments and turning points relevant to the theme.

Thematic Study: The Early Anglo-Saxons c.400–800	
Key Topics	Content Learners should have studied the following:
The development of Kingship and kingdoms in Britain and Ireland	The first Saxons (including the roles of Vortigern, Hengist and Horsa c.450); <i>Mons Badonicus</i> ; reasons for early expansion of kingdoms by c.600, the emergence of <i>Bretwaldas</i> (overkingship); administration; the heptarchy; reasons for the rapid rise and fall of kings in the seventh century; reasons for later Northumbrian expansion; reasons for and consequences of the emergence of the Mercian supremacy (including Aethelbald, 716–757 and Offa, 757–796); the extent of power of early Anglo-Saxon kings c.825.
Religion and the Christian Church in Britain and Ireland	Religious belief before Augustine (British and Germanic); the process of Christianisation (starting with Augustine 597); the role and impact of the Roman and Celtic Church; the significance of the Synod of Whitby, 664; challenges faced by the Church (including issues surrounding lay foundation, patronage of ministers, relations between the Church and kings); Theodore and the ‘golden age of monasteries’; reasons for and consequences of the growth of monasteries; monasteries in the countryside (the ‘minsters’); the role of Alcuin and Anglo-Saxon missionaries to Europe.
Economic and social life in Britain and Ireland	Rural and urban settlements; reasons for the emergence of towns (churches, fortifications and trade), other construction (including Offa’s Dyke); the economy; farming, land issues (including the concept of ‘bookland’), craft-working; the expansion of internal and external trade (including the introduction of a systematic coinage); social structure, lordship, families and kinship; law and law-making (dispute, feud and resolution including <i>wergild</i> and the use of violence); burials.
Cultural change in Britain and Ireland	Language (Latin and the vernacular languages), nature and extent of cultural assimilation and identity; literature (including the writings of Gildas, <i>Beowulf</i> and the writings of Bede), education and learning (including the influence of the school at Canterbury); art, architecture, dress, jewellery; religious artefacts, art and literature (including the <i>Book of Durrow</i> and the <i>Lindisfarne Gospels</i> , c.710–720).

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Depth studies	Content Learners should be aware of debates surrounding the issues outlined for each in-depth topic:
Athelbald, Offa and the Mercian supremacy	The Mercian supremacy as a turning point in the development of kingship and kingdoms; the extent of the supremacy; reasons for and consequences of the rise of Mercia as a political force; the role of Athelbald; the role of Offa (including Offa's leadership, the significance of Charlemagne's letter to Offa, Offa's currency reforms, the significance of Offa's Dyke).
Augustine and the process of Christianisation	The short and long-term impact of Augustine's mission of 597; apostasy and pagan reaction; the role of the Celtic Church and Columba; the Synod of Whitby (664) as a possible turning point; problems of organisation, Theodore and the spread of monasteries; reasons for and consequences of the growth of monasteries; Christianity in the countryside; the relationship between the Church and kings; the Church and the revival of town life; Christianisation and cultural change.
Communities and kinship	The nature of local communities in Britain and Ireland (population groups, folk areas, tribes, spheres of lordship or regions); the reasons for and consequences of changing relationships within and between local communities (as determined by ethnicity, kinship, social status and/or ties of lordship); the regulation of relationships, especially disputes.